



Cloudy, cold 30/26 • Tomorrow: Snow, breezy 31/21 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 19, 2025 • \$4

Prosecutor quits over order on EPA funds

Veteran of U.S. attorney's office in D.C. refuses to carry out DOJ demand

BY SPENCER S. HSU, CAROL D. LEONNIG AND NICOLÁS RIVERO

The head of the criminal division in the U.S. attorney's office in D.C. resigned Tuesday morning after declining to comply with an urgent Trump administration demand to freeze the assets of a multibillion-dollar Biden administration environmental grant initiative, according to the official's resignation letter and two people familiar with the matter.

Veteran prosecutor Denise Cheung's resignation came in response to a Justice Department effort to assist President Donald Trump's head of the Environmental Protection Agency, who said last week that he would try to rescind \$20 billion in grants awarded by the Biden administration for climate and clean-energy projects, according to the two people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they weren't authorized to discuss the matter publicly.

Cheung wrote in her resignation letter that while she and the FBI asked the bank handling the

SEE PROSECUTOR ON A6

HHS: Firings at CDC, FDA and other agencies total in the thousands. **A3**

Pentagon: DOGE officials arrive, and firings are expected soon. **A6**

Virginia: Youngkin promises help but says layoffs are necessary. **B1**

U.S. cancels plan to end coronavirus test program

Officials debated trashing \$500M in kits; site to get them free was closing

BY LENA H. SUN AND CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

The Trump administration reversed a plan late Tuesday to shut down the government website that ships free coronavirus tests to households, after The Washington Post reported that the administration was preparing to end the program and was evaluating the costs of destroying or disposing of tens of millions of tests.

The Post reported on Tuesday afternoon that the administration was evaluating the costs of destroying tests that would otherwise be provided free to Americans, citing two officials at a federal public health preparedness agency and internal documents reviewed by The Post. A half-hour before the planned shutdown, Department of Health and Human Services spokesman Andrew Nixon sent a statement to The Post confirming that COVIDtests.gov would shut down at 8 p.m. Tuesday. But he said the tests would not be destroyed and "will remain in inventory until they meet their expiration date."

SEE TESTS ON A4



EVELYN HOCKSTEIN/REUTERS

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, center left, with Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov, right, on Tuesday in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. The talks, which excluded Ukraine and U.S. allies in NATO, are apparently seen by Moscow mostly as a means of warming U.S.-Russian ties. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said talks should not take place "behind the backs of key players," namely Ukraine and Europe.

Trump's transactional style unnerves Taiwan

BY KATRINA NORTHROP AND VIC CHIANG

TAIPEI, TAIWAN — President Donald Trump has spent his first few weeks in the White House talking about land deals like the real estate developer he once was.

He has threatened to annex Greenland — refusing to rule out military force to do so — and has suggested using "economic force" to make Canada the 51st American state. He has repeatedly talked about taking over the Gaza Strip — referring to the area as the "Rivi-

Island fears eagerness to redraw national borders will embolden Beijing

era of the Middle East" — and his envoys are trying to broker a deal with Russia that could cost Ukraine some of its land.

This transactional approach is unnerving many in Taiwan, who fear it will embolden Chinese leader Xi Jinping to press ahead with

his plans for "reunification" with Taiwan, an island democracy of 23 million people that has never been ruled by the Chinese Communist Party. Some fear Trump and Xi might even use Taiwan as a bargaining chip in a trade deal.

"Trump's rhetoric is doing China's work for it in Taiwan," said Ryan Hass, a China and Taiwan expert at the Brookings Institution and a former national security official in the Obama administration.

"With each statement by Trump that degrades the principle that

territorial boundaries must not be redrawn by force or coercion, propagandists in Beijing likely are giving each other high-fives," Hass said.

Xi, the strongest Chinese leader in decades, has made "the rejuvenation of the Chinese nation" one of his top priorities, and that includes taking control of Taiwan, where nationalist forces fled when a civil war ended with Communist victory in 1949.

Over the past three years, Beijing has dramatically stepped up

SEE TAIWAN ON A11

Judge to probe DOJ's dismissal of charges against NYC mayor

BY SHAYNA JACOBS AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

NEW YORK — A federal judge has called a hearing for Wednesday on the Justice Department's motion to drop criminal charges against New York Mayor Eric Adams (D), a decision that ignited a week of extraordinary open conflict between career prosecutors and Trump appointees, and

Governor, with power to remove him, questions Adams's ability to serve

led to at least seven resignations. Allegations that Adams agreed to cooperate with the Trump administration on immigration

enforcement in part to get his case withdrawn have separately triggered a political crisis in New York, with four deputy mayors quitting their posts and Gov. Kathy Hochul (D) saying she has concerns about Adams's ability to remain in his position.

Hochul said she would be meeting with key leaders in Manhattan on Tuesday "for a conversation about the path forward,

with the goal of ensuring stability for the City of New York." The governor noted that she has the power to remove the mayor from office but that no governor has exercised that power throughout New York's history.

The Rev. Al Sharpton was among those who met with Hochul. He told reporters afterward that the governor did not plan to make a decision on

whether to take action against Adams before Wednesday's court hearing. Hochul's office did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

"Overturning the will of the voters is a serious step that should not be taken lightly. That said, the alleged conduct at City Hall that has been reported over the past two weeks is troubling

SEE ADAMS ON A7



KATE MEDLEY FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Jeff Nix, a third-generation apple grower in North Carolina, saw Helene wipe out one of his most productive orchards. "We are four months into this thing now," he says. "What's the timeline?"

After Helene's ruin, North Carolina farmers face daunting decision

Awaiting aid, they must determine whether they can — or should — start over

BY BRADY DENNIS IN EDNEYVILLE, N.C.

Linda Pryor had checked on one of her family's sprawling apple orchards, where tree trunks still bore the high-water marks from Hurricane Helene and a sea of rotten, flood-tainted fruit carpeted the ground.

She had navigated washed-out sections of road and a missing bridge to check on other fields, where endless rows of corn lay flattened, brown and unharvested — and where the raging waters had deposited appliances and hot tubs, children's toys and trash cans and tires.

At one 20-acre plot off Fruitland Road, which had just become accessible four months after the storm, she found her 42-year-old husband, Adam, rumbling through the field on a bulldozer, beginning to clear fallen trees, boulders, chunks of concrete and other debris. A gully had to be filled and soil leveled and tested. So much work remained, with the spring planting season fast approaching.

"We are running out of time," said Linda, 40.

She estimated their farm already had sustained losses of as much as \$1 million from the

SEE NORTH CAROLINA ON A8

IN THE NEWS

Pope Francis's hospitalization The 88-year-old pontiff is suffering from pneumonia in both lungs, the Vatican disclosed. **A12**

'Zizians' arrested Three members of a cultlike group authorities have linked to six killings, including that of a U.S. Border Patrol agent, were arrested in Maryland. **B1**

THE NATION **Before historic floods** that killed at least 17 people, parts of Kentucky and West Virginia had already seen up to twice their normal precipitation so far this winter. **A9**

THE WORLD **A worker-poet** in China hopes for papers that will better her life in the big city. **A10** **Russia freed** an American citizen who had been arrested on drug-smuggling charges. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **A freeze** on wind-power permits is upending the plans of Eastern states and putting climate goals out of reach. **A15** **Confusion reigned** after the FBI dropped out of a free workshop about scams targeting seniors, Michelle Singletary writes. **A16**

THE REGION **A decline** in new HIV cases in D.C. has led to a significant cut in federal funding for prevention work. **B1** **A federal judge** temporarily blocked the Trump administration's firing of the chair of the Merit Systems Protection Board. **B1**

STYLE **Carrie Coon**, who's in Season 3 of "The White Lotus," is back in her wheelchair as a character brimming with intense emotion. **C1**

FOOD **Comedian** Gus Constantellis made his mom a TikTok star. When she died, he kept cooking. **E1**

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